



The b3nd!ng ov the rul3z

Once upon a time, there was communication... then technology happened. Is the written word doomed?

Ram Mohan Rao

My smmr hols wr CWOT. B4, we usd 2 go 2 NY 2C my bro, his GF & thr 3 :-@ kds FTF. ILNY, its gr8. ...

That excerpt is from a Scottish schoolgirl's essay on her summer holidays. A translation goes like this: "My summer holidays were a complete waste of time. Before, we used to go to New York to see my brother, his girlfriend and their three screaming kids face to face. I love New York; it's a great place."

Instances such as these are ringing alarm bells in certain quarters. College students, too, are increasingly using SMS lingo in their essays and assignments.

Is our language taking a beating as a result of the use of technology? Will your children ever be able to understand Shakespeare and Keats? Will they write novels worth reading? On the other hand, are people thinking faster when they use techno-speak, and putting their point across better? What will these trends ultimately lead to?

That's a mixed bag of questions, but there are two basic sides to the debate: one which says that language is indeed degrading as a result of technology, and the other which says that it's all about evolution—that just as language has evolved with the times, there is now an accelerated evolution as a result of technology.

Slips Of The Langue

Professor David Crystal, one of the world's foremost linguists, notes that Henry Alford, then the Dean of Canterbury, wrote a book called *A Plea for the Queen's English* in 1864, in which he effectively said that the English language was going to the dogs. Dr Crystal notes that it's always been that way—each generation condemns the slips in language, but what's happened ultimately is that the language has kept on growing.

"There has never been a pure language," he says. "Language is not always logical." We may infer that there is always room for change.

Naveen Halemane, a research scholar at Mysore University's Department of Linguistics

feels youngsters are the ones effecting most of the changes. He says, "Most informal expressions are created and used by youngsters. Older people usually get along somehow. Nevertheless, they bother about 'rules' being neglected. Most abbreviations these days are incomprehensible for older people. The use of 'u' in place of 'you' by youngsters has sometimes resulted in high-ranking officers rejecting applications."

This may be true, but things will change—even if it is just for the sake of the simple fact that today's youngsters will be the adults of tomorrow.

What about instances such as the Scottish schoolgirl's essay? Crystal is of the opinion that it is the teacher's job to instruct students in the correct use of language—that there is a place to be informal and a place to be formal, and the debate need not go beyond that.

Tech-speak shortcuts are to be found in Web chat. Be it in a Yahoo! adult chat-room or one between office colleagues, the use of shortcuts such as "gr8" doesn't raise any eyebrows.

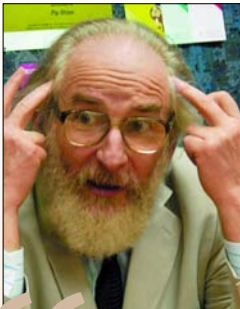
Not any more, at least. Many would say that shortcuts are shortcuts; it doesn't mean language is deteriorating. That may be true. However, the degradation of language is an intangible; it is a continuous process—something you cannot quantify, something that happens without your notice.

Consider the following response to a Digit contest:

"....thx a lot...i can belive on my luck.....actually i was a bit late in sending my images and never expected to win....any ways... my postal add is as follows....."

This kind of writing is at the centre of the debate. On one side, critics of tech-speak may say: What can be said of the

mind of a person who writes like this? It's obvious his or her language skills have been dumbed down. Can such a person ever participate in a debate over real issues? And so on. On the other hand, defenders of today's language trends say that there is no cause for alarm whatsoever, and that the person was merely shooting off a message hurriedly, without paying attention to detail.



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Prof David Crystal,
Linguist and leading
language expert

